

LESSON GUIDE

Linework & Basic Shapes

Every drawing begins with a mark. This lesson builds the muscle memory and perceptual skills that all future lessons depend on: controlled line-making, geometric shape construction, and the foundational observation skill of seeing in shapes rather than in objects.

4-WEEK PLAN

Week 1 — Pencil Control & Mark-Making

Explore pencil grips, pressure control, and mark variety. Fill pages with parallel lines, curved lines, and ghosted marks without a ruler.

Week 2 — Lines & Exercises

Practice straight lines across the page, curved lines with consistent arc, and overlapping ellipses at different angles and sizes.

Week 3 — Basic Shapes

Draw boxes, spheres, cylinders, and cones from observation and imagination. Rotate them mentally before drawing.

Week 4 — Combining Shapes

Break down three objects from life into their basic shape components. Draw each object twice: once from life, once from the shape analysis alone.

KEY CONCEPTS

Line Quality

The character of a line determined by pressure, speed, and confidence. Clean, purposeful lines communicate skill before anything else.

Basic Geometric Shapes

Circles, squares, triangles, and their three-dimensional equivalents — spheres, cubes, cylinders, cones. The building blocks of every complex form.

Ellipses & Foreshortened Circles

Circles in perspective become ellipses. The degree of an ellipse indicates the angle of the circular plane relative to your eye level.

Organic vs. Geometric Form

Geometric forms have mathematically precise edges. Organic forms are irregular and varied. Most drawn subjects combine both.

Negative Space & Shape Recognition

The space around and between objects. Drawing the negative space rather than the object itself is one of the fastest accuracy tools in drawing.

Gesture & Contour Lines

Gesture lines capture movement and character. Contour lines describe edges. Both are essential tools with different expressive purposes.

ESSENTIAL RESOURCES

- [How to Hold a Pencil — YouTube](#) (multiple grip demonstrations)
- [Draw a Box Lesson 1 — Free online course](#), first four lessons
- [New Masters Academy — Linework fundamentals playlist](#)
- [Proko — Drawing basics and mark-making exercises](#)
- [Ctrl+Paint — Digital mark-making and line quality library](#)